Though Babur would not see much of the rest of the country, Hindustan was a land of baffling variety, each region rich in its own culture and language. In the fifteenth century, there had been an explosion of vernacular languages, which grew alongside the great literary languages, Sanskrit and Persian; Bengali, Gujarati, Hindustani, Kannada, Kashmiri, Oriya, Punjabi, Sindhi, as well as scores of dialects were spoken by substantial portions of the population. Each region had its own microclimate, from the heat of the Gangetic plains and the plateau of the Deccan, to the cool mountains of Kashmir, and the lush torpor of the Deccan sultanates.

It was an empire largely comprising ploughs and bullocks and cultivated fields. Eaton has described the melange of societies that would meld together as the semi-nomadic Timurids settled into largely agricultural Hindustan to create their Mughal Empire:

> Central Asia's semi-pastoral culture was based on rearing livestock and mastering horse-based warfare, and it assessed wealth largely in terms of movable assets: sheep, horses, goats, camels. The Indian world Babur encountered, by contrast, was one of ploughs and bullocks, a sedentary and agrarian society that understood wealth mainly in terms of fixed resources: harvested grain, manufactured goods, precious metals. If the kingdom that Babur established in India was initially a transplant of Central Asia's semi-pastoral oasis culture, his descendants would root the state ever more deeply in India's agrarian economy, its socio-religious culture and its political life.

♦

But all these changes in the composition of society and the economy would make themselves felt in the future, for after four short years in Hindustan, Babur died in 1530 after appointing his eldest son, Humayun, as his heir. Problems would arise almost immediately for Humayun as his three brothers, Kamran, Askari, and Hindal, challenged his accession. The Timurids did not have a system of primogeniture* and instead followed a law of co-sovereignty in which all royal princes had an equal right to rule. Timurid mirzas, sons, and brothers of the ruler, were raised to become ferocious warriors and competitors, able rulers of tribes of men so that the strongest and most capable amongst them would become Padshah when the